The Working Page

Essays on Printing, Type and Reading

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CHAPTER 1

The Compositor's Day

Margaret Lowe

Every page printed by hand passed through a compositor before it reached the press. He stood at a pair of cases, the capitals in the upper one and the small letters in the lower, read a few words of his copy and picked the sorts one at a time into the composing stick in his left hand. When the stick was full he slid the lines onto a galley; when there were lines enough for a page he tied them up with cord and set the page aside until the whole forme could be imposed and locked into its chase. Joseph Moxon described the routine in his *Mechanick Exercises* of 1683–84, the first full manual of printing in English, and most of what bibliographers later wrote about the compositor starts from his account (Gaskell 1972).

The work was paid by the piece. A compositor was credited with the number of ens he set, and his speed, his spelling and his care decided what the reader received. That is why the compositor matters to anyone who edits an early printed text: between the author's manuscript and the printed sheet stood a man with his own habits, working against the clock, who could misread a word, run short of a letter or change the spelling to make a line fit.

Reading the evidence of the type

The type itself keeps a record of this work. A sort with a nicked serif or a broken stem prints the same flaw wherever it is used, and once the page has been printed the compositor distributes the type back into the case, so the damaged letter turns up again a few pages later. Charlton Hinman followed hundreds of such letters through the Shakespeare First Folio of 1623 and worked out the order in which its pages were set, which compositor set them and how the work moved between the cases (Hinman 1963). His method rested on patience and a Hinman collator, but its premise was simple: type is a finite stock, and its movements can be traced.

Spelling gave a second kind of evidence. One compositor preferred *doe* and *goe*, another *do* and *go*; one set a colon where his partner set a comma. Where the copy did not dictate a form, the compositor's preference showed through, and a page set by one man reads differently from a page set by another. Bibliographers assembled such preferences into profiles and used them to assign pages and to weigh the authority of a reading (Gaskell 1972).

Printers of the mind

The weakness of these methods lay in what they assumed about the printing house. Analyses of type recurrence often supposed that a shop worked through one book at a time, a compositor setting the pages in order and a press printing each forme as soon as it was ready. D. F. McKenzie tested that picture against the records of Cambridge University Press for the years 1696 to 1712, which survive in unusual detail, and found that it did not hold (McKenzie 1969). Several books were in production at once. Compositors moved from one job to another as copy arrived; pressmen printed sheets of different books in the same week; work stopped and restarted as paper, money or the author's revisions allowed.

McKenzie's conclusion was that bibliographers had built their arguments on "printers of the mind", an orderly workshop that existed in their reasoning and not in the archive. A pattern found in the type could be explained by more than one sequence of work, and a single sequence could not be inferred from it without outside evidence. His essay did not end the study of compositors, but it changed its tone: inferences now came with the conditions under which they held.

What the compositor made

The compositor also produced something larger than any single page. Because the same setting of type printed every copy of a sheet, an edition of several hundred copies carried the same text, page for page, to readers who would never meet. Elizabeth Eisenstein made this repetition the centre of her account of early modern Europe: the identical copy, she argued, allowed scholars in different cities to compare the same tables, maps and texts, to correct them in later editions and to build on one another's work (Eisenstein 1979). The second essay in this volume returns to her argument and to the objections it met.

Yet the copies of an edition were never quite identical. Errors were often caught while a sheet was on the press, and the forme was unlocked

and corrected without the sheets already printed being thrown away, so that corrected and uncorrected states were bound up together in the same edition (Gaskell 1972). Hinman found such press variants throughout the Folio (Hinman 1963). The compositor's day, in other words, made both the stability that Eisenstein described and the small instabilities that bibliographers spend their careers collating.

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CHAPTER 2

What Fixity Meant

Daniel Okafor

Few books in the history of the book have been argued with as long as Elizabeth Eisenstein's. *The Printing Press as an Agent of Change* appeared in two volumes in 1979 and proposed that the shift from script to print was itself a cause of the Renaissance revival of learning, of the Reformation and of the new science of the seventeenth century (Eisenstein 1979). Her case rested on a few features that print had and manuscript did not: dissemination in hundreds of copies at once, standardisation of text and image, and above all what she called typographical fixity, the capacity of an edition to preserve a text unchanged and to let it be corrected and improved in the next.

The thesis was large, and its reception divided along a familiar line. Historians of ideas found in it an explanation of why scholarship became cumulative after 1500. Historians of printing pointed to the variety of what presses actually produced, from error-filled almanacs to pirated editions, and asked whether fixity was a property of print or a result that some printers achieved some of the time.

Credit and piracy

Adrian Johns gave the second answer its fullest form (Johns 1998). Studying the London book trade of the seventeenth century, he found that readers had good reason to distrust what they bought. Editions were reprinted without permission, attributed to authors who had not written them, or issued with the wrong date and imprint. The Stationers' Company kept a register of titles to settle disputes among its members, but the register protected the trade's own arrangements rather than the author's text. A reader who wanted to know whether a printed book was what it claimed to be had to rely on the reputation of the printer and the bookseller, on the people who vouched for the edition, and on the conventions of the shop where it was sold.

Fixity, in Johns's account, was therefore something made. It took the work of authors who watched over their proofs, of booksellers who guarded their names, and of institutions such as the Royal Society, which licensed and supervised the books it sponsored. His most cited example is the Astronomer Royal, John Flamsteed, who saw his observations printed in 1712 in an edition he had not approved and spent years trying to recover and suppress it. Where Eisenstein saw a feature of the technology, Johns saw a set of practices that had to be learned, and that could fail.

Circuits and models

The debate between the two positions is easier to follow with a map of what a book passes through. Robert Darnton drew one in 1982: a communications circuit that runs from the author to the publisher, the printers, the shippers, the booksellers and the readers, and back to the author, with each stage shaped by economic, political and intellectual conditions (Darnton 1982). The model placed the history of books among the people who handled them, and many studies of the 1980s worked through it stage by stage.

Thomas Adams and Nicolas Barker objected that Darnton's circuit described the trade and lost sight of the object. They proposed a model built around the book itself and the events in its life: publication, manufacture, distribution, reception and survival (Adams and Barker 1993). The difference matters to the argument about fixity. In Darnton's circuit, fixity belongs to the relations between printers, sellers and readers; in Adams and Barker's model, it is also a question of which copies survived, where, and in what state.

The form of the text

D. F. McKenzie widened the question further in his Panizzi lectures, published in 1986 (McKenzie 1986). Bibliography, he argued, should study texts as recorded forms and the processes of their transmission, including their production and their reception, and it should treat the form of a text as part of its meaning. His example was William Congreve, whose plays changed character when they were reset for the collected *Works* of 1710: the new layout divided the scenes differently, marked entrances in a new way and invited a different kind of reading.

From McKenzie's position the quarrel over fixity looks less like a quarrel. An edition can fix the words of a text and still change how it reads; a reprint can keep the meaning and lose the form that carried it. Eisenstein

described what the press made possible, and Johns described what it took to make that possibility hold (Eisenstein 1979; Johns 1998). Both are histories of the same pages, written from different ends of the circuit.

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CHAPTER 3

Punches, Matrices and the Name Garamond

Lucía Ferrer

Before a compositor could set a page, someone had to make the letters he picked from the case. Printing spread quickly: Lucien Febvre and Henri-Jean Martin estimated that fifteen to twenty million copies of books had been printed in Europe before 1500 (Febvre and Martin 1976). Every one of those copies was printed from type cast in a mould, and every typeface began as a set of steel punches cut by hand at the size the reader would see.

The sequence of work is well documented, though the hand skills it required have mostly been lost (Carter 1969). The punchcutter shaped the end of a steel bar into the reversed form of a letter, filing and engraving it and checking it against smoke proofs. The enclosed spaces of the letter, the counters of *a*, *e* or *o*, were usually struck into the punch with a counter-punch, which let him repeat the same counter in several letters of the fount. Fred Smeijers, who has cut punches himself, argues that the counterpunch explains much of the consistency of sixteenth-century faces: the shapes were related because they were made with the same tools (Smeijers 1996).

From punch to sort

The hardened punch was driven into a bar of copper to make a matrix. The matrix had to be justified, filed so that the letter sat at the right depth and position, and then fitted into a hand mould, an adjustable box of steel and wood into which the caster poured an alloy of lead, tin and antimony. Each pour gave one sort, and the finished type, rubbed and dressed, was sold to printers by weight (Gaskell 1972).

Punches were the founder's capital. They could be used for decades, lent, inherited or sold, and a set of strikes from them allowed another foundry to cast the same face. This is why the faces of a few French punchcutters of the mid-sixteenth century spread across Europe within a generation.

Whose letters

It also made attribution difficult. A face appears in a printer's book long after it was cut, under the printer's name and not the cutter's. Harry Carter's survey of early typography set out the evidence available to sort these questions: specimen sheets, inventories, contracts and the books themselves (Carter 1969). Hendrik Vervliet spent decades applying it to the French Renaissance, comparing faces letter by letter across hundreds of books, and his catalogues redistributed many types long credited to Claude Garamont among his contemporaries, Robert Granjon and Pierre Haultin among them (Vervliet 2008).

The name Garamond had a modern history of its own. When foundries in the early twentieth century revived "Garamond" for machine composition, several of them took as their model types that had been cut not by Garamont but by Jean Jannon, a printer at Sedan, some sixty years after Garamont's death. Beatrice Warde pointed this out in 1926. The revivals kept the name, and many digital faces still carry it.

What the reader sees

None of this is visible on the page as a reader meets it. The reader judges a book by how easily it reads. The bibliographer sees, in the same page, the trace of a punchcutter's files, the wear of a matrix and the habits of the caster who justified it. Early printers bought their type by size names, pica, english, long primer, and judged it as the reader did, by the page it made (Gaskell 1972). The history of type begins in steel, but it was always written for that page.

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